Of course, it was not all warfare and invasion. There were relatively peaceful periods when trade and culture flourished. Taxila remained a centre of learning and new urban centres appeared, especially under Kushan rule. Buddhist ideas made their way into Central Asia and then eventually to China. Nonetheless, it is fair to say that the North West was unsettled for several centuries after the decline of the Mauryas. The heart of Indian civilization had already shifted from the Sapta-Sindhu region to the Gangetic plains during the Iron Age. Now, the action shifted to the coasts due to a boom in maritime trade. We see this all along the coast from Gujarat in the west to Kerala in the south-western tip and then all along the eastern seaboard up to Tamralipti in Bengal.

Maritime trade was not new to India. As we have seen, the Harappans traded actively with Mesopotamia. In the Iron Age, centres like Dwarka may have maintained these links. We know that by the time of the Mauryans, Tamralipti was a thriving port with links as far as Sri Lanka. We also know that the empire had diplomatic and trade links with the Greek kingdoms of the Middle East. However, it was from the second century BC that we see trade with both the Graeco–Roman world and South East Asia jump an order of magnitude. A Tamil epic from this period, the *Silapaddikaram*, tells us about the story of two lovers—Kannaki, daughter of a captain, and a merchant's son Kovalan. This how the epic describes the great port of Puhar (or Kaveripatnam):[2]

> Great and renowned kings envied the immense wealth of the seafaring merchants of the opulent city of Puhar
>
> Ships and caravans from foreign lands poured in abundance rare objects and diverse merchandise
>
> Its treasure would be untouched by the entire world, bound by the roaring seas

The literature of this period is full of references to trade. This is especially true of the *Sangam* anthologies. These collections of early Tamil poetry appear to have been put together in a series of ancient conferences. Exact dates are not available, but they probably took place between the third century BC and the sixth century AD. Madurai appears to have been the venue for most of these gatherings. However, it is said that the tradition